- Transgenic mice are used for testing the safety of vaccines.
- Transgenic animals are used for testing toxicity in animals that carry genes which make them sensitive to toxic substances than non-transgenic animals exposed to toxic substances and their effects are studied.
- Transgenesis is important for improving the quality and quantity of milk, meat, eggs and wool production in addition to testing drug resistance.

10.6 Biological products and their uses

A biological product is a substance derived from a living organism and used for the prevention or treatment of disease. These products include antitoxins, bacterial and viral vaccines, blood products and hormone extracts. These products may be produced through biotechnology in a living system, such as a microorganism, plant cell or animal cell, and are often more difficult to characterize than small molecule drugs. Through recombinant DNA technology it is possible to produce these biological products on demand. There are many types of biological products approved for use -they are, therapeutic proteins, monoclonal antibodies and vaccines. Health care and pharmaceutical industries have been revolutionised by biotechnological proteins. Hormones and antibodies are produced commercially, primarily for the medical industry. Recombinant hormones like Insulin, Human growth hormone, Recombinant vaccines and recombinant proteins like human alpha lactalbumin are available today.

Animals are used as bioreactors to produce desirable proteins. Antibodies are substances that react against the disease causing antigens and these can be produced using transgenic animals as bioreactors. Monoclonal antibodies, which are used to treat cancer, heart disease and transplant rejection are produced by this technology. Natural protein adhesives are non toxic, biodegradable and rarely trigger an immune response, hence could be used to reattach tendons and tissues, fill cavities in teeth, and repair broken bones.

10.7 Animal Cloning

Cloning is the process of producing genetically identical individuals of an organism either naturally or artificially. In nature many organisms produce clones through asexual reproduction.

Cloning in biotechnology refers to the process of creating copies of organisms or copies of cells or DNA fragments (molecular cloning).

Dolly was the first mammal (Sheep) clone developed by Ian Wilmut and Campbell in 1997. Dolly, the transgenic clone was developed by the nuclear transfer technique and the phenomenon of totipotency. **Totipotency** refers to the potential of a cell to develop different cells, tissues, organs and finally an organism.

The mammary gland udder cells (somatic cells) from a donor sheep (ewe) were isolated and subjected to starvation for 5 days. The udder cells could not undergo normal growth cycle, entered a dormant stage and became totipotent. An ovum (egg cell) was taken from another sheep (ewe) and its nucleus was removed to form an enucleated ovum. The dormant mammary gland cell/udder cell and the enucleated ovum were fused. The outer membrane of the mammary cell was ruptured allowing the ovum to envelope the nucleus. The fused cell was implanted into another ewe which served as a surrogate mother. Five months later dolly was born. Dolly was the first animal to be cloned from a differentiated somatic cell taken from an adult animal without the process of fertilization **(Fig. 10.8).**

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